



McClellan's revolver

This .44 caliber Colt Dragoon was carried by McClellan during the Civil War. This popular model was first issued to troops after the War with Mexico in 1848.

General-in-chief

Shortly before the humiliating Union defeat at First Bull Run, McClellan's forces had won a series of notable victories in western Virginia. Following these successes, he took command of the Army of the Potomac, then became the Union Army's general-in-chief on Scott's retirement in 1861.

McClellan's organizational brilliance did much to restore confidence to the Union war effort, and most importantly, to Irvin McDowell's volunteers, who had just been disgraced at Bull Run. A chastened North, which had now seen firsthand the potential downsides of precipitate military action, was more than willing to give McClellan ample time to train and prepare his army.

Presidential protection

McClellan did not have unlimited time, and his imperious manner toward civilian leaders, including his commander-in-chief, won him few friends. Lincoln did his best both to shield his top general from political pressures and to educate him in political realities, but McClellan's egotism made him a poor student. Republican leaders became increasingly frustrated with the outspoken Democrat and opponent of emancipation, who, as yet, had won no significant